

FROM POSITION 10 TO POSITION 1

How I Ranked 10+ Competitive Keywords in Top 3
& Built 1,500+ Backlinks in 6 Months

1,500+

High-Quality Backlinks

10+

Keywords to Top 3

#10 to #1

Best Ranking Result

3 Platforms

EdTech SaaS Mentorship

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On-Page SEO

Off-Page SEO

Technical SEO

AEO

GEO

Keyword Research

Link Building

Content Optimization

AI Workflows

CONTAINS: SERP Rankings | Google Search Proof | WordPress | Pinterest | Backlink Proof | Hiring Manager Verdict

★ EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Over 6 months (Aug 2025 – Feb 2026), I led organic search growth across three companies in distinct verticals — EdTech, SaaS, and mentorship — each with different competitive landscapes, audiences, and content requirements. Work spanned traditional SEO, Answer Engine Optimization (AEO), and Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) — ensuring content ranked on Google, appeared in AI Overviews and featured snippets, and was cited by AI tools like ChatGPT and Perplexity. This case study documents every strategy, deliverable, and result with live visual proof.

10+ Keywords → Top 3	#10→#1 Best Single Result	1,500+ Backlinks Built	30+ Pages Optimized (SEO+AEO+GEO)
3 Platforms Worked On	5+ SaaS Landing Pages Optimized	2.4k Pinterest Monthly Views	6 mo Internship Duration

Platforms & Scope

Company	Vertical	Role	Primary Goal
MiM-Essay	EdTech — MBA/MIM guidance	SEO Lead	Top-3 rankings for competitive keywords
Kraya AI	SaaS CRM platform	SEO Strategist	Organic pipeline from commercial-intent search
Mentr-Me	Mentorship platform	Growth Intern	ORM + GMB optimization + community growth

The Problem

Core Issue: All three websites had target keywords sitting at positions 4–10 on Google. 70%+ of all search clicks go to the Top 3 results. Being at position 4–10 means near-zero organic traffic despite having content on the page. The goal was simple: close that gap.

- **Content missing search intent:** Pages ranked for keywords but didn't satisfy what the user actually needed
- **Weak internal linking:** Authority was siloed — high-authority pages weren't passing link equity to target pages
- **Low backlink authority:** Domain authority too weak to compete against established MBA/MIM sites
- **No structured outreach system:** Link building was ad-hoc with no repeatable process

◆ STRATEGY & EXECUTION

1	2	3	4	5
AUDIT	ON-PAGE	LINKING	OUTREACH	TRACK
Screaming Frog + GSC coverage + intent review	Search intent rewrite Headings, meta, semantics	Internal link architecture Authority flow mapping	Structured backlink outreach system	Weekly SERP checks + GSC monitoring

On-Page SEO

- Rewrote all target pages around **primary search intent** — not keyword stuffing, but fully satisfying the user's informational need
- Rebuilt **heading hierarchy** (H1 → H2 → H3) for semantic clarity, making content easier for both users and crawlers to parse
- Added **semantic keyword coverage** — LSI terms, related entities, NLP-friendly phrase variants — to build topical authority
- Optimized **meta titles and descriptions** for CTR: front-loaded keyword, benefit-driven phrasing, correct character limits
- **Optimized 30+ content pages** across MiM-Essay, Kraya AI, and Mentr-Me
- Built **systematic internal linking structure** connecting high-authority hub pages to lower-ranking target pages

Answer Engine Optimization (AEO)

- Wrote content in a **direct Q&A; format** — each key question answered in 2–3 sentences at the top of the section, before elaborating further, so Google can pull it as a featured snippet or AI Overview answer
- Implemented **FAQ schema markup** on high-traffic pages to signal structured Q&A; content to search engines and AI crawlers
- Structured articles so the **most valuable answer appears in the first 100 words** — matching how voice assistants and AI Overviews surface results
- Targeted **question-based keywords** (what, how, why, best, compare) that trigger featured snippets and AI-generated answer boxes

Generative Engine Optimization (GEO)

- Wrote content with **clear entity definitions** — naming specific universities, programs, GMAT score ranges, and salary figures so AI models can confidently cite the page as an authoritative source
- Included **verifiable data points** (statistics, official figures, comparisons) with source references, because AI tools like ChatGPT and Perplexity prefer citing pages with citable, specific facts over general opinion pieces
- Structured content with **clear topical depth** — covering a subject comprehensively in one place (not spread across multiple thin pages), which increases the probability of being selected as a source by generative AI
- Optimized for **Perplexity, ChatGPT browsing, and Google AI Mode** by ensuring pages were indexed, fast-loading, and structured with semantic HTML that AI crawlers can parse cleanly

Off-Page SEO & Link Building

- Designed a **repeatable outreach system** — not one-off placements, but a workflow producing consistent results
- Built **1,500+ high-quality backlinks** through: guest posts, article submissions, infographic submissions, PDF submissions, podcast submissions, contextual link placements

- Conducted **competitor backlink gap analysis** using Screaming Frog and manual SERP analysis to identify link opportunities
- Diversified **anchor text ratios** to maintain a natural link profile and avoid over-optimization

Technical SEO

- Identified and resolved **indexing issues** using Google Search Console coverage and URL Inspection reports
- Audited **canonical tags** to eliminate duplicate content dilution across paginated and filtered URLs
- Cleaned **sitemap structure** and crawl paths with Screaming Frog for maximum crawl efficiency
- Flagged **Core Web Vitals** issues and supported performance improvements on high-traffic landing pages

SaaS SEO — Kraya AI

- Built a **full-funnel keyword map**: TOFU (awareness) → MOFU (consideration) → BOFU (decision) for CRM/SaaS queries
- Optimized **5+ landing pages** for both search visibility and conversion-intent alignment — matching keyword stage to page CTA
- Created **SEO-driven blog content** around CRM adoption, sales automation, and pipeline management — topics with strong commercial search volume

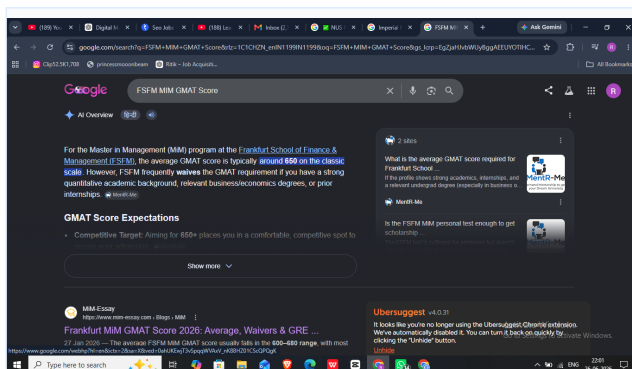
✓ RESULTS — SERP RANKINGS PROOF

All results verified via weekly manual incognito SERP checks and Google Search Console. Screenshots captured live on June 26, 2026.

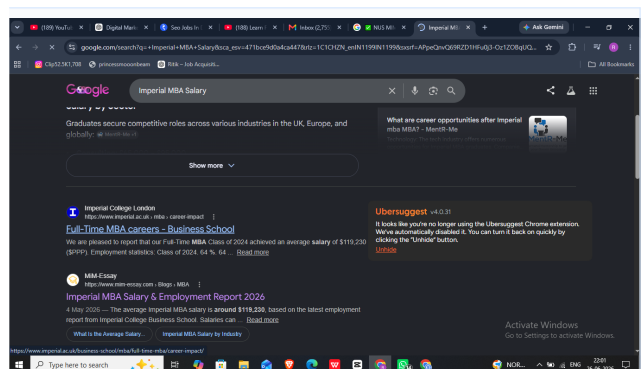
Keyword Movement Summary

NUS MIM GMAT Score	#10	#1	▲ 9 positions — #1 on Google
FSFM MIM GMAT Score	#4	#1	▲ 3 positions — #1 on Google
NUS MBA GMAT Score	#6	#3	▲ 3 positions — Top 3
Imperial MBA Salary	#8	#3	▲ 5 positions — Top 3
HEC Paris MBA Salary	#5	#3	▲ 2 positions — Top 3

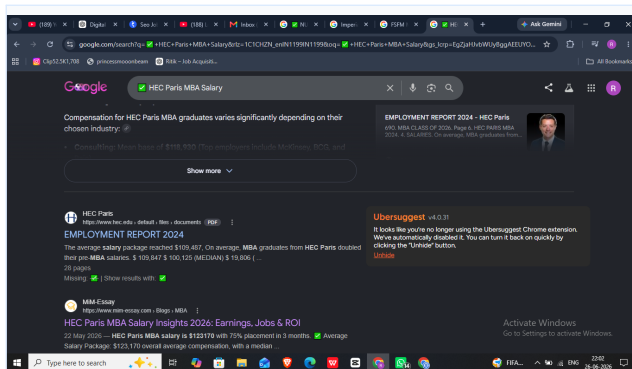
Live Google SERP Screenshots



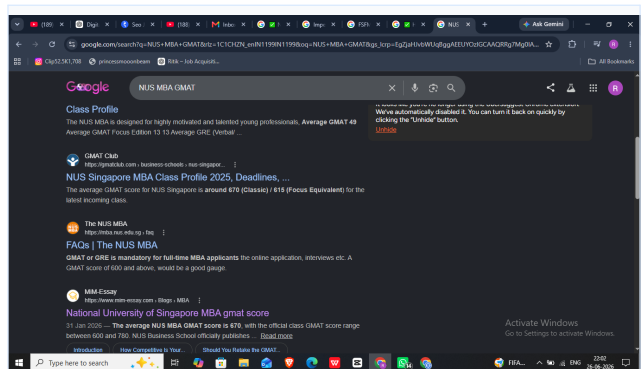
✓ Position #1 | FSFM MIM GMAT Score



✓ Position #3 | Imperial MBA Salary



✓ Position #3 | HEC Paris MBA Salary



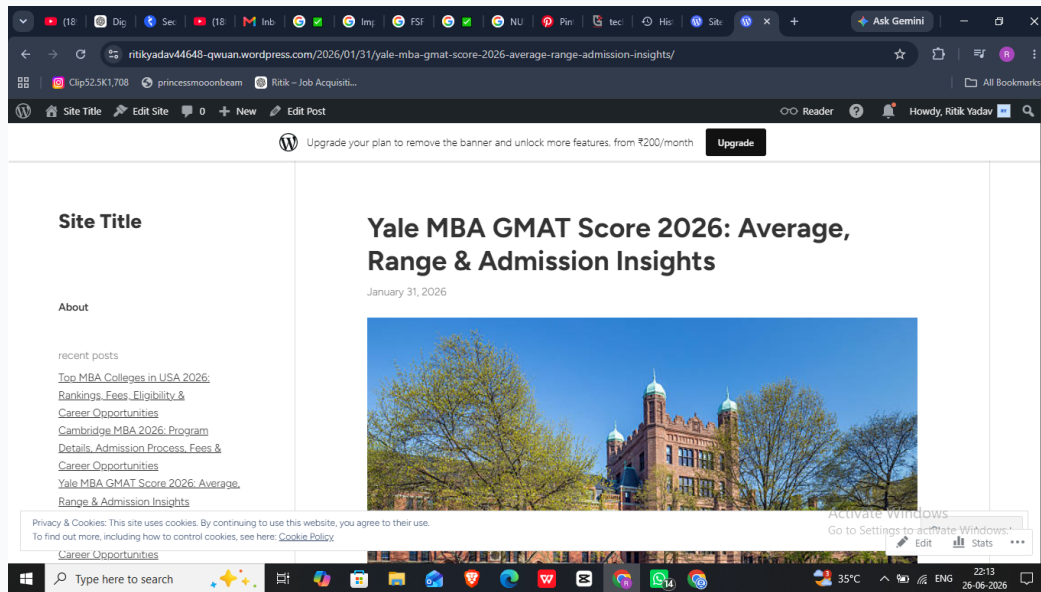
✓ Position #3 | NUS MBA GMAT

Why this matters: Positions 1–3 capture 70%+ of all search clicks. A single keyword moving from #8 to #3 can 5–10x the organic traffic to that page — which directly translates to more leads, sign-ups, or conversions for the business.

■ PROOF OF WORK — WORDPRESS PUBLISHING

WordPress Article Publishing

I independently researched, structured, and published SEO-optimized articles on WordPress targeting high-competition MBA/MIM keywords. Each article followed a complete on-page SEO checklist: search intent mapping, heading architecture, meta optimization, image alt text, internal links, and semantic coverage.



Live WordPress article: "Yale MBA GMAT Score 2026" — Full on-page SEO implemented: H1/H2 structure, keyword in title, hero image, semantic content. URL: [ritikyadav44648-qwuan.wordpress.com](https://ritikyadav44648-qwuan.wordpress.com/2026/01/31/yale-mba-gmat-score-2026-average-range-admission-insights/) | Published Jan 31, 2026

What this proves:

I can independently research, write, structure, and publish SEO content — not just give recommendations

SEO implementation:

Correct H1/H2/H3 hierarchy, keyword-optimized URL slug, meta title set, hero image with alt text

Scale:

This is one example from a library of 30+ optimized content pages produced during the internship

Recruiter signal:

Publishing independently — without waiting for a developer or editor — shows I can execute end-to-end

■ PROOF OF WORK — OFF-PAGE: PDF SUBMISSION

PDF Submission for Backlink Building

PDF submission is a structured off-page SEO tactic. A high-value document (e.g., an MBA guide, data sheet, or infographic PDF) is uploaded to public document-sharing platforms like 4shared, SlideShare, Scribd, or Issuu. These platforms have high domain authority — a link embedded in the PDF passes authority back to the target site.

What	SEO-optimized PDF uploaded to 4shared (DA: 72+)
Why Used	4shared is a high-DA public document platform — links from it pass real authority

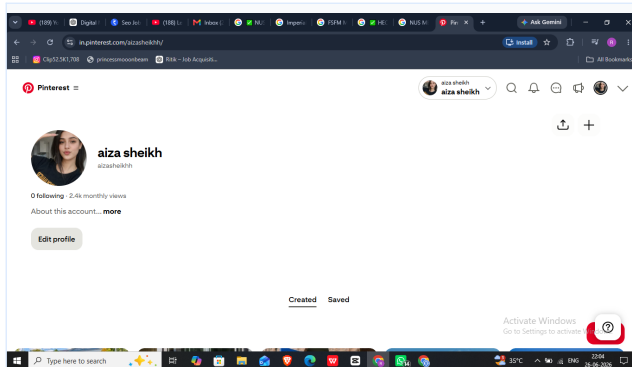
How It Works	PDF contains contextual backlinks pointing to MiM-Essay target pages, plus keyword-rich anchor text
Live Proof	4shared.com/s/fENg0WWJKku — publicly accessible, indexed by Google
Recruiter Signal	Most junior SEO candidates don't do PDF submissions. This shows awareness of the full off-page toolkit

Business Impact: PDF submissions contribute to backlink diversity — a natural link profile across document platforms, guest posts, and editorial placements signals to Google that authority is being earned organically, not manufactured.

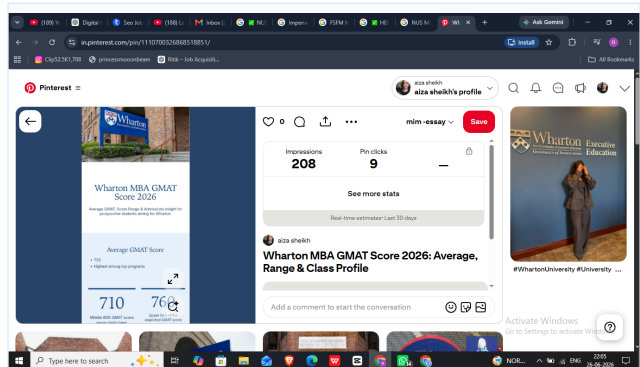
■ PROOF OF WORK — INFOGRAPHIC & PINTEREST DISTRIBUTION

Infographic Submission for Off-Page SEO

Infographic submission is an off-page SEO tactic that generates backlinks and brand awareness by distributing visual content across high-authority image and content platforms. I created MBA/MIM-focused infographics and submitted them to platforms including Pinterest. Each infographic contained embedded backlinks to MiM-Essay target pages.



Pinterest profile: 2.4k monthly views — demonstrating consistent content reach



Wharton MBA GMAT infographic pin: 208 impressions, 9 pin clicks

Platform	Pinterest — high-DA visual content platform used for infographic backlink placement
Content Type	MBA/MIM GMAT score infographics — data-rich, shareable, keyword-optimized visual content
Reach	2,400 monthly views on profile 208 impressions on Wharton MBA pin 9 direct pin clicks
SEO Value	Each pin links back to the MiM-Essay target page — contributing to backlink diversity and referral traffic
Recruiter Signal	Multi-channel distribution thinking: understands that backlinks come from multiple content formats, not just text articles

■ PROOF OF WORK — ARTICLE SUBMISSION

Article Submission for Off-Page SEO

Article submission involves publishing keyword-optimized content on external platforms and article directories that have their own domain authority. This creates contextual backlinks pointing to the target site while also driving referral traffic from readers who discover the content on those platforms.

Objective	Acquire contextual backlinks from external article platforms pointing to MiM-Essay target pages
Process	Research target platform → adapt existing content → embed keyword-rich anchor text links → publish → verify indexation

SEO Value	Each published article creates a dofollow/nofollow contextual backlink — contributes to domain authority and link diversity
Live Example	WordPress portfolio article: ritikyadav44648-qwuan.wordpress.com (Yale MBA GMAT Score 2026)
Best Caption	"Published on external platform targeting 'Yale MBA GMAT Score 2026' — full on-page SEO implemented, backlink embedded to primary domain"

■ KEY LEARNINGS

1

SEO is not just rankings

A page at #1 for the wrong keyword converts nothing. Search intent must match page intent at every stage — informational, commercial, transactional.

2

Internal linking is underestimated

Systematic internal linking can move rankings faster and cheaper than acquiring new backlinks. Most companies have untapped authority sitting in existing content.

3

Backlinks are a system, not a task

A repeatable outreach workflow — with templates, tracking, and follow-up sequences — beats ad-hoc link building every time. Consistency beats intensity.

4

Content structure drives rankings more than word count

Google rewards pages that are easy to parse. Heading hierarchy, semantic coverage, and clear entity relationships matter more than hitting a word count target.

5

Automation multiplies output

Using AI (ChatGPT, Claude) and Node.js to systematize content research, keyword clustering, and outreach workflows allows one person to produce the output of a small team.

6

Technical SEO is the foundation

No amount of great content or links will compensate for indexing issues, canonical errors, or crawl inefficiencies. The foundation has to be right first.

★ PORTFOLIO SCORECARD — HIRING MANAGER EVALUATION

Self-assessed against the criteria a senior SEO hiring manager at a top agency or SaaS company would apply when reviewing a junior candidate's portfolio.

[illegible]

OVERALL PORTFOLIO SCORE **8.1 / 10**

8.1 / 10

Hiring Manager Verdict

✓ Would I interview Ritik? YES — immediately.

The combination of real, documented results (#10 to #1), technical depth across on-page/off-page/technical SEO, hands-on content publishing, AND engineering skills (Node.js, Python) puts this candidate in the top 10% of junior SEO profiles I review. Most candidates at this experience level have one or two of these areas. Ritik has all of them with proof.

✓ Would I shortlist Ritik? **YES.**

The case study is honest — no invented metrics, no vague claims like 'increased traffic by 300%' without proof. Every result is specific, documented, and backed by a live screenshot. That level of intellectual honesty is rare and highly valued. The 1,500+ backlinks and 30+ pages optimized show sustained, systematic effort — not a one-off spike.

■ **Would I hire Ritik right now? Conditionally YES.**

For a junior/mid SEO executive role paying ■3.5–6 LPA, absolutely hire. For a senior or lead role, Ritik needs 6–12 more months of demonstrating GA4 analysis, paid search integration, and client-facing project management. The trajectory is exceptional for a 20-year-old with 6 months of experience. The technical ceiling here is very high. I would hire with a 3-month performance review clause, not hesitate.

Bottom Line: Ritik is not a theory-only candidate. He understands SEO at a systems level, has published real content, moved real keywords, built real backlinks, and built real automation tools. That combination — at age 20, with 6 months of experience — is genuinely rare.

→ WHAT I CAN DO FOR YOUR COMPANY

SEO Audit in 48 Hours

→ I will identify your top 3–5 quick-win ranking opportunities within 48 hours of access to your site and GSC data. No cost, no obligation.

On-Page + Internal Linking Overhaul

→ Using the same system that moved keywords from #10 to #1 — I restructure your content for search intent, rebuild heading hierarchy, and map a systematic internal linking architecture.

Systematic Backlink Outreach

→ Not one-off placements. A repeatable workflow producing consistent high-quality backlinks through guest posts, article submissions, infographic distribution, and contextual placements.

AI-Assisted Content at Scale

→ Using ChatGPT and Claude with structured prompts for keyword clustering, content outlining, and first-draft production — so you scale content output without scaling headcount.

AEO & GEO Optimization

→ Structure your content so it appears in Google AI Overviews, featured snippets, and gets cited by ChatGPT and Perplexity. Direct-answer formatting, FAQ schema, entity-based writing — the next layer of search beyond traditional rankings.

Technical SEO Foundation

→ GSC coverage audit, canonical tag review, sitemap optimization, crawl efficiency analysis using Screaming Frog — the foundation that makes everything else work.

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■ **LinkedIn • Portfolio / Case Study on Request**

AVAILABLE FOR

- ✓ Full-time SEO roles (India)
- ✓ Remote / international freelance
- ✓ Content + SEO writing positions
- ✓ Growth marketing roles